

Note Perfect

Notebooks come at a premium, but for anyone who needs to be mobile, it's a premium that's worth paying. Laptops generally lag considerably behind desktop PCs in absolute performance and upgrades can be really expensive. Four manufacturers, namely Compaq, Toshiba, IBM, and Dell dominate the international laptop market. Most of the laptops however, are actually manufactured in Taiwan.

SMART TIPS

Size/weight: The weight ranges from 1.5 kg to 4 kg and it could be as small as 1 inch in thickness. External power supplies and peripherals can add considerably to the weight.

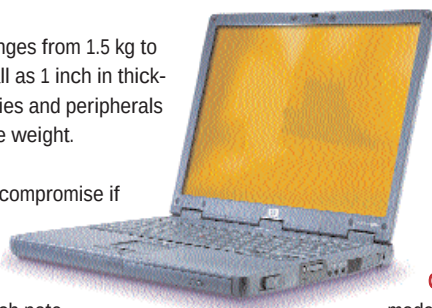
Display: This will require a compromise if you decide on an ultra-portable model. Most displays now support 1024x768 pixels and a 14-inch notebook display may be larger than most 15-inch desktop CRT units.

Processor: While the Crusoe, Duron and Athlon 4 mobile processors are available, Intel P-III and Celeron processors are more popular.

Battery: Realistically, the up time for most lithium ion battery powered models would be about three to four hours.

Keyboard: If you are going to be doing a lot of typing, a larger keyboard will add considerably to your comfort. Having the eight cursor-control keys is very important.

Drives/bays: Makes sense to have all the drives (floppy, DVD/CD ROM) built into the main casing. However, a hot-



swappable bay gives you greater flexibility.

Hard drive: Capacity ranges from 6 GB to 50 GB. Most users find 12-20 GB enough. You don't save much by going for a smaller drive, and you pay a lot more for the bigger drives.

Communication: Look for a built-in 56K modem with a RJ-45 connector for your phone line. If you spend a lot of time on a network, you will also want a built-in Ethernet port. While IrDA is available on many units, this has not really been a popular option.

Pointing device: You can choose between a pointing stick (like IBMs Trackpoint), or a touch pad. Pointers are easier to control but can give you a sore finger especially if used for a long stretch of time.

Ports: Most peripheral devices connect to a USB port; make sure you have at least two USB ports. You will also need parallel (for printers), serial, and PS/2 (for keyboard/mice) ports.

Docking stations: This is useful if you are using your notebook as a desktop replacement.

Also Remember...

■ Laptop upgrade cost a bomb, so make sure that you go for a system that will satisfy your needs (without upgrades) for the next couple of years at least.

■ While all mobile processors have some kind of built-in power management technology and several power saving options, battery life is always a concern (especially due to the display).

■ An additional battery pack, a video-out port, an external volume control and a graphical battery life indicator are all very useful.

■ If you go for a top-end system, you should be prepared to pay a heavy premium. A better choice would be to try and anticipate your requirements in the foreseeable future and look for a match for them.

■ Most notebooks come with a one-year warranty on parts and labour, though options for two- or three-year warranties are available at an extra cost. Make sure a service centre that stocks spares is easily accessible to you.

	General	Desktop replacement	Ultraportable
You need	A lightweight model but still don't want to sacrifice screen and keyboard size	Something that gives you all the functionality of your existing desktop PC	An ultra light notebook; something with a bit more panache
Look for	A model that has an extra bay that would hold a CD/DVD-ROM, floppy drive, add-on battery or even a CD-RW drive. These generally will offer a 13/14-inch XGA display and weigh less than 3 kg	Something that weighs about 4 kg and has a 15-inch display (1280x1024 SXGA). Most peripherals are accommodated within the laptop chassis	There are certain tradeoffs such as a somewhat cramped keyboard and a smaller (and maybe lower resolution) display. The connectivity options are usually limited and battery life is
Our pick	Zenith 21A	Niskibuki 1GHz IBM Thinkpad, A21M	ACI Profile III Compaq Presario 17XL361
Price range	Up to 1,20,000	Up to Rs 2,00,000	Up to Rs 1,50,000

